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Collected Articles of
Padmabhushan Prof. J. P. Naik

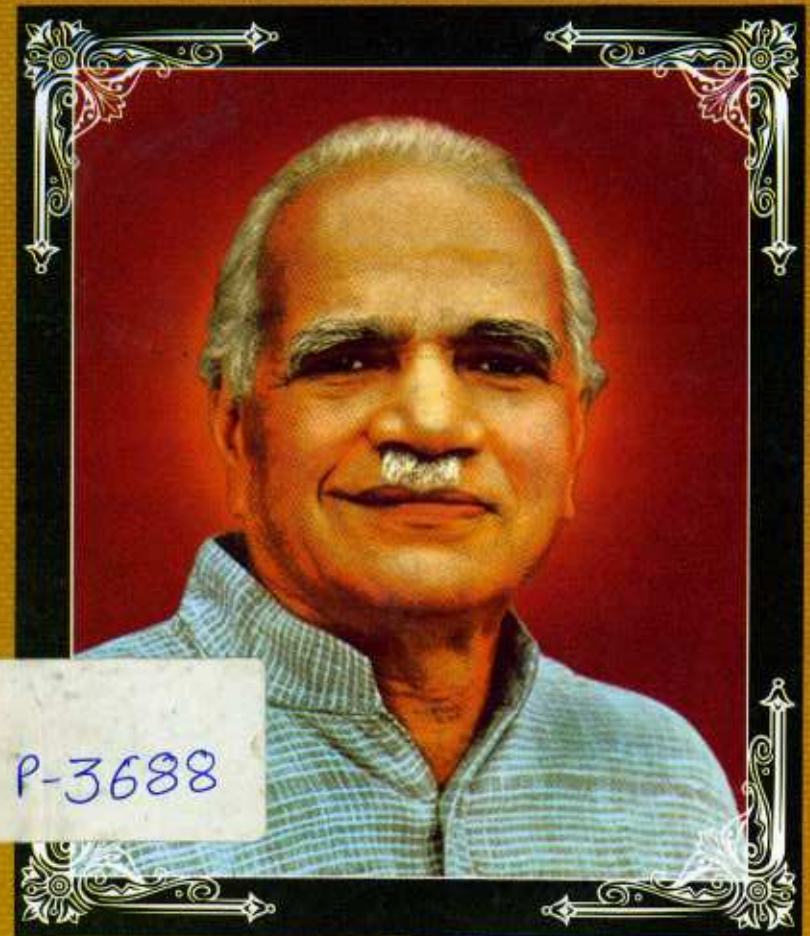
Dr. Yeshwant R. Waghmare
Dr. A. Sai Babu



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Collected Articles of Padmabhushan Prof. J. P. Naik

Volume 1
Education and Development



Dr. Yeshwant R. Waghmare
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Collected Articles of
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Volume I
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AUTHORSPRESS

in Association with

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he would have entered another Uppin Betigeri even after a crowded interregnum of forty eight years, mixing with the villagers, talking excitedly about plans for change, sitting on the floor of a hut regaling himself on *jowar* bread and curds, entirely unmindful of how he looked in soiled *khadi* shorts and a shirt with an irreparable rent in its back. That was the real Naik, known simply as 'J.P.' to his friends who are legion.

Preface

It is indeed a privilege and honour for us to have been assigned the task of collating the writings and articles of the founder of various educational systems which are in vogue in India, and even abroad, Prof. J.P.Naik. Prof. Naik had recognised as early as in 1940s that India is a vast country with large population of multiple caste, class, regional and religious dimensions, and as such a single educational system would not suit it. In order to provide education for the entire population he therefore advocated various types of educational systems. However, besides education, he was also concerned with the 'health programmes' for the entire population in general, but more so for the rural population who is deprived of even the basis necessities of health care facilities. Prof. J.P.Naik was well known to educationists all over the world as an outstanding visionary, planner and organiser. He was involved in setting up various institutions such as Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR), National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration (NIEPA/ NUEPA), Mauni Vidyapeeth, Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), Indian Institute of Education (IIE), and others. He was the most outstanding single individual having the greatest influence on education reforms for developing countries in general and India in particular.

Prof. Naik's early life was full of struggles. He came from a poor rural family, and would have been dragged into the rural agricultural trap; but for his intelligence, love for education, and strong desire to help people, and our country, by devising methods of appropriate systems of education for rural as well as

urban folks. He had a brilliant academic career, and loved literature as well as mathematics. It was in his early college education years that he participated actively in India's liberation movement under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi, and served a prison sentence. It was during his prison term that he gained good knowledge of medicine and medical practice, and helped the inmates. He launched the programme of 'Education for All, Health for All' and made every effort to make it successful. However, because of the circumstances prevailing then he had limited success. The eminent educationist Prof. A.R.Kamat writes about him, "In his last work, 'Education Commission and After', undertaken during the very last phase of his life, Naik frankly admits that the framework adopted in the Education Commission Report about education and development had basic weaknesses, since it did not even refer to the extreme poverty and deprivation in Indian Society, and the highly unequal distribution of earnings, wealth and political power -the fundamental problems of Indian Society, which need to be faced equally.... Naik's departure from the Indian educational scene has created a large void which cannot easily be filled. In a sense, it was the end of an epoch. It is for the on-going generations of Indian educationists to work for his idea of radical reconstruction of Indian education with a clearer perspective". It was indeed a great pleasure for one of us (ASB) to be his disciple.

'Collected Articles of Prof. J.P. Naik' has been compiled in three volumes. The first volume deals with his contributions in the fields of Primary Education, Elementary Education, Higher Education and Education for Rural Development. Volume No. II contains his contributions in the area of Policy Studies, and Volume No. III contains monographs concerning his contributions in educational development for scheduled castes and tribes, and his reflections and assessment for the future.

We are very thankful to the librarians of various institutions such as NCERT, NIEPA, ICSSR, JNU, IIE and others for providing us the necessary assistance in collecting the articles, speeches and reports for inclusion in these three volumes. One of us (ASB) is particularly grateful to Smt. Nirmal Malhotra, Librarian of NIEPA for personal help in procuring the documents from other institutions as well. Some of the documents were in the form of photocopies of articles whose originals could not be traced. Some

of the articles had to be retyped as well as scanned to minimise errors in their reproduction. We are grateful to Smt. Medha Sonsale, Smt. Hemangi Katre, Smt. Sujata Joshi and Shri Aswad Purohit for their assistance in suitably consolidating the manuscript.

We are also grateful to Dr. Ambika Jain, Director, Centre for Educational Studies (CES), and a former student of Prof. J.P.Naik, for all the assistance she provided.

We are also extremely grateful to the members of the Executive Council and the members of the Board of Trustees of Indian Institute of Education, for the confidence they showed in assigning this task to us. In particular, we are extremely grateful to Dr. Chitra Naik, Chairperson, Board of Trustees of Indian Institute of Education (IIE), and Dr. Shankarrao R. Gowarikar, Secretary General of IIE and Chairman of the J.P.Naik Birth Centenary Celebrations Committee for their continued guidance, assistance and encouragement for the completion of this project.

We specially appreciate Shri Madhukar Patil for all the assistance that he and his staff provided in the preparation of the manuscript, including getting a part of the manuscript scanned, and the necessary corrections required. The cover page of all the three volumes is also designed by Shri Patil.

Finally, on behalf of the editors as well as our Institute we express our sincere and special gratitude to Sudarshan Kcherry and Authorspress to publish these volumes in a record time.

Editors

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Primary Education

Provision of School Places in Class I to V (1948)*

One of the most important problems in the administration of primary education is to decide, as accurately as possible, the provision of school-places required for a programme of compulsory education. In the First and the Second Five-Year Plans, the policy adopted was to provide as many school-places in classes I to V as would be equal to the number of children in the age group of 6-11 that was proposed to be enrolled. For example, the target for the Second Plan was to enrol about 65 per cent of the children in the age-group of 6-11. Therefore, the total number of school-places in classes I-V for which provision was made was 300 lakhs or 65 per cent of the total estimated population of children (about 460 lakhs) in the age-group of 6-11. In other words, the formula adopted was as follows:

School-places to be provided in classes I to V = Total number
of children in the age-group of 6-11 proposed to be enrolled.

It was known that a large number of children in the under-age and over-age groups were reading in classes I to V; but it was felt that things would ultimately adjust themselves and that the total enrolment in classes I to V would be equal to the total number of children in the age-group of 6-11. The implications of this assumption are not always fully realised. It is, therefore, necessary to examine them a little more in detail.

**Educational Quarterly*, 1948

The usual formula for calculating the provision of school-places or total school enrolment is as follows:

$$\text{School-places to be provided} = A + \frac{P \times Y}{100D}$$

where

- A = number of under-age and over-age children enrolled;
- P = Population of children proposed to be enrolled;
- X = Percentage of enrolment;
- Y = Average duration of school life; and,
- D = Duration of the course.

Under ideal conditions, when $A=0$, $X=100$ and $Y=D$, the above formula reduces itself to the simple form:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Number of school-places to be provided in classes I to V} &= \\ P &= \text{Total number of children in the age-group of 6-11.} \end{aligned}$$

It is, therefore, obvious that the assumption underlying the First and the Second Plans is true under ideal conditions only, i.e.,

- a) When there are no under-age or over-age children reading classes I to V, i.e.,
 $A=0$;
- b) When every child is enrolled in school and there are no non-attending children, i.e., $X=100$ and
- c) When there is no wastage and every child remains in school for the full period of the course, i.e., $Y=D$.

In practice, however, such ideal conditions are never realised. A is never equal to zero. On the other hand, the number of under-age and over-age children attending classes I to V is very large and at present, it is about 23.7 per cent of the total enrolment in classes I-V. Similarly, X is not generally equal to 100 and Y is rarely equal to D. At present, the percentage of wastage is about 60 and Y varies between 2.3 and 2.6 years. It is quite possible to reduce it; but the day when every child would remain in school for the full period of five years is yet rather distant. Our calculations, therefore, will have to be made on slightly different assumptions.

ASSUMPTIONS FOR THE THIRD PLAN

What would be the reasonable assumptions for the Third Five-Year Plan (1961-62 to 1965-66) is the next issue. 'A' will continue to be large even during the Third Five-Year Plan and, it is, therefore, suggested that this may be taken at the existing percentage, i.e., about 23.7 per cent of the total because the present pattern of enrolment is not likely to change materially during the next five years. 'X' may be taken at 100 because, if an effort is made, it would be possible to bring every child into school for some period, however small. Y may be taken at 3.5 years. As stated earlier, it varies between 2.3 years and 2.6 years at present and we may, therefore, assume that intensive efforts would be made to reduce wastage, and that the average period of school life would be prolonged to 3.5 years. 'P' may be taken at 580 lakhs, which is the latest estimate given by the Planning Commission for the total population of children in the age group of 6-11. I personally feel, however, that this would prove to be an underestimate in view of the latest projected population for 1966 given by the Central Statistical Organisation, and that the correct figure would have to be taken at 600 lakhs.

Substituting in the above formula:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{school-places to be provided} \\ \text{in classes I-V} &= A + \frac{P \times Y}{100D} \\ &= A + \frac{600 \times 100 \times 3.5}{100 \times 5} \text{ lakhs} \\ &= A + 420 \text{ lakhs} \\ &= 130 + 420 \text{ lakhs} \\ &= 550 \text{ lakhs} \end{aligned}$$

(A is taken at the present rate, i.e., 23.7 per cent of the total of 550 lakhs).

It will thus be seen that we need to provide 580 lakhs of school-places by 1965-66. The enrolment that is proposed to be reached at the end of the Second Five Year Plan has been tentatively estimated at 340 lakhs. Hence, a provision of 210 lakhs of additional school-places will have to be made during the Third Five-Year Plan.

IMPLICATIONS

The exact implications of this provision should be clearly understood. For clarity of reference, however, they have been stated below:

- i) University of school provision will have to be made if these targets are to be reached. That is to say, a school will have to be provided within easy walking distance from the home of every child.
- ii) Of the 600 lakhs of school-places provided, only about 420 lakhs are expected to be utilised by children in the age-group of 6-11. This works out at about 70 per cent of the total.
- iii) About 130 lakhs of places will be utilised by children outside the age group of 6-11. Of these, those below the age of 6 would be very few, but the vast majority would be of the age-group of 11-14. As stagnation is reduced, these children will be pushed up to classes VI-VIII and their place will be taken up by children in the age-group of 6-11.
- iv) Every child in the age-group of 6-11 is expected to be enrolled and stay in the school for 3.5 years. Since permanent literacy is attained in this period, the evil of lapse into illiteracy is expected to be reduced to the minimum by the end of the Third Plan.
- v) In the simpler language of common sense, these targets imply the enrolment of about 92 per cent of the children in the age group of 6-11.

These calculations are made on the basis of a uniform enrolment of 92 per cent for boys and girls and for all States. In practice, however, the enrolment of girls is likely to be much lower in the States of U.P., Bihar, M.P., Rajasthan and Orissa. The target for boys also is not likely to exceed 85 per cent in several States. All things considered, therefore, a provision of about 180 to 200 lakhs of additional school-places in classes I-V is all that can be realistically forecast. The provision of additional school-places made in the First Plan 60 lakhs and that in the Second Plan was 100 lakhs. Hence, the requirement of the Third Plan may be said to be about three times that of the First Plan and twice that of the Second Plan.

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Some Problems of Single-Teacher Schools (1952)*

Our attitude to single-teacher schools has now been undergoing a significant change. Till about 1924, we seemed scarcely conscious of their existence. Then the Report of the Royal Commission on Agriculture condemned them as inefficient institutions which contributed largely to wastage.¹ This verdict was endorsed by the Report of the Hartog Committee whose recommendations on the subject² led, in some areas, to a determined crusade to abolish them altogether. In Baroda, for instance, almost all the single-teacher schools were abolished, either by closure or by the appointment of an additional teacher, and a rule was adopted to the effect that no new primary school would be opened unless there were at least 75 children to attend it. The results were disastrous. The total number of primary schools in the State fell from 2,996 in 1926-27 to 2,542 in 1937-38. In the latter year, the number of single-teacher schools was only 33! As many as 1,325 small villages (out of a total of 2,969 in the State) which could not manage to send 75 children to a school and whose population was 4,95,347 or 21 per cent of the total population of the State, had no educational facilities whatsoever. Moreover, these villages were largely inhabited by backward tribes like the Rani Paraj who needed education most and it was precisely they that were denied of it under this policy.³ Experiences of this type began to turn the tide of educational opinion. As early as 1929, J.A. Richey had advocated the view that single-teacher schools were indispensable to India and could be

**Educational Quarterly*, Vol. IV, 1952

improved.⁴ Littlehales strongly condemned the Baroda policy of eliminating single-teacher schools and said:

There will always be small villages, where the employment of a single teacher is all that can be economically justified and wastage in school effort will always be with us especially when illiteracy is large, so that single-teacher schools will have to remain in parts of Baroda just as they remain in small and out of way villages in other parts of the world. What is desirable is that where a single-teacher school exists, the teacher should be conscientious in character and trained. It has not been found impossible in other countries for a single-teacher to conduct several small classes in a small village; it should not be impossible in Baroda. I advise the opening of single-teacher schools in places where they have been closed and transfer to them of trained teachers.

This saner view has now come to be accepted and the reformers' emphasis has shifted from the elimination of the single-teacher schools to the more important and practicable problem of their improvement. This is indeed a happy sign and augurs well for the future of rural education.

If the single-teacher schools are to be improved it goes without saying that their problems must be squarely faced and solved. These are almost innumerable and have not unfortunately received that attention from research students and administrators to which they are entitled on merits. As my humble contribution to the study of this interesting problem, I propose to discuss here some important issues that arise in the administration of single-teacher schools which exist, almost exclusively in backward rural areas.

REDUCTION IN NUMBERS

Although the proposition that single teacher schools cannot be abolished is irrefutable, it stands to reason that every attempt should be made to reduce their number. Some of the important suggestions put forward and tried from this point of view are given below:

- a) *Branch Schools*: Since the main difficulty of single-teacher schools is that the teacher has to handle 4 to 5 classes at

a time, the idea of establishing a central or Suzerain school in a bigish village with branches in small neighbouring villages is often put forward. The central school is necessarily a multi-teacher school; but the branch school is a single-teacher institution and teaches only the two lower standards. Under this plan, therefore, several advantages are secured at once. The very young children are not required to walk over long distances to reach the central school and can study for some time in their own village. (The grown-up boys and girls can, of course, attend the central school without inconvenience.) Secondly, the teachers of the single-teacher schools have to handle only two classes at a time, and, therefore, can maintain a higher level of efficiency; and thirdly, the branch schools are not regarded as independent units but merely as parts of the central school and are placed directly under its control. Therefore, the constant supervision of the central school helps materially in maintaining the tone of the single-teacher branches. The experiment was given a very large trial in the Punjab and at one time, the State had as many as 2,707 branch schools.⁵

The main objection to this proposal is that it creates a large number of incomplete schools, i.e., schools which provide a course whose duration is shorter than four years. It is common knowledge that such schools do not impart permanent literacy and that those of its students who do not pursue their studies elsewhere (generally they do not) are very likely to relapse into illiteracy. A drive to eliminate the incomplete schools is also recommended as a method of reducing waste and it appears that, under the plan of branch schools, we fall into one evil while excluding another. The Punjab experiment, therefore, did not succeed and the enthusiasm with which the Hartog Committee recommended it is no longer shared. Nevertheless, the idea can be tried in areas where, owing to compulsory education it is possible to compel older children to attend the central school and where the distance between the central school and its branches does not exceed one mile. No great results however, are expected from this

device, although it has a useful application in a limited sphere.

- b) *Compulsion*: Better results are obtained by the expedient of introducing compulsory education. Take, for instance, all villages with a population between 500 and 1,000. When attendance is voluntary most of such villages usually have an enrolment of 30 to 50 in the local schools and ordinarily only one teacher is appointed to conduct each of them. Under compulsion attendance will rise to 15, or at least 12 ½ per cent of the population and hence all such villages will have an attendance of 70 or more children and can be given two or more teachers. The universal introduction of compulsion, therefore, is the surest way to reduce the number of single-teacher schools.
- c) *Co-education*: The third device of reducing the number of single-teacher schools is to adopt co-education at the primary stage. When girls' schools are separate, they are very often single-teacher schools only and one usually comes across biggish villages with a multi-teacher boys' school but a single-teacher girls' school. There is no justification for the segregation of the sexes at the primary stage and the popular prejudice against it is dying fast, even in rural areas. Travancore-Cochin has, for instance, already adopted co-education at this level.⁶ Bombay City has followed suit since last year, and given the right approach and educative propaganda, it should be possible to introduce co-education in all our primary schools and also to appoint mixed staffs in a fairly large number of them. This reform, if carried out, would probably have the most far reaching effect in reducing the number of single-teacher schools. It will, of course, have several other important advantages as well and one feels that it ought to be accorded a very high priority.

LEAVE OF TEACHERS

Another important question that needs administrative planning is that of granting leave to the teachers of single-teacher schools. The general practice is this: casual leave to the teacher is to be

sanctioned by the Chairman of the local school committee; and other kinds of leave are to be sanctioned by a higher official—generally the Chief Executive Officer of the School Board or Committee employing him—who can also appoint a substitute to take charge of the school. In practice, these arrangements break down very often. In several places, there is no local school committee at all, or even if there is one, it does not function satisfactorily. In these instances, the teacher is a law unto himself. A common trick practised by an unscrupulous teacher is to write a report saying that he had to proceed on leave on account of unavoidable circumstances (the unusually fertile imagination of such teachers can invent any number of them), to leave it in the school, and then to go away on an unofficial leave. If any officer turns up in his absence, he is shown the report. If no one does, the teacher tears out the report on return and fills in bogus attendance as if he was on duty. The best way to avoid such irregularities is to set up an active school committee or at least to have an active chairman. But this is not always possible.

Another common evil is that the school remains closed for a long time when the teacher goes on leave and a substitute is not or cannot be appointed. Although teachers are required to intimate their intention to go on long leave sufficiently in advance, this is not always done, and sometimes it is not also possible. When this happens, great delays are caused in appointing a substitute because the official making the appointment has to follow a prescribed procedure. Some time is lost before the news of the teacher's absence reaches the headquarters; then the office red-tape must have its time, and sooner or later an order of appointment is issued to a candidate from the approved list. Some more time is lost before the candidate gets the order and joins his post. Sometimes he chooses not to join; then the order has to be sent to another candidate, and so on until somebody turns up at the school. And all this while, the school remains closed for lack of a teacher!

It must be made clear that the evil is not imaginary. It is very real and very grave. A pilot survey carried out for an year in six districts of an important State showed that more than 10 per cent of the single-teacher schools had remained closed at some time

or the other because the teacher went on leave and a substitute was not appointed in time; that no substitute was generally appointed (or could be appointed) if the duration of the leave was less than 30 days; and that several schools were remained closed longer than a month owing to difficulties of the type mentioned above. The situation has, therefore, to be taken note of and duly remedied.

One proposal made after a careful statistical investigation carried out in Maharashtra State is this: The single-teacher schools in a district should be divided into convenient groups of 10 to 25. A big primary school, central to this group should be selected as the controlling school and an extra relieving teacher should be attached there. Whenever a teacher of a single-teacher school proceeds on leave of more than seven days' duration, he intimates the headmaster of the controlling school who at once sends the relieving teacher to take charge of the school and then sends the papers to the headquarters for formal orders. Under this arrangement, the chances of a single-teacher school remaining closed are reduced to the minimum and prompt action to send a substitute is made possible. The only drawback is that it needs a reserve of relieving teachers at 5 per cent. But the total number of single-teacher schools and its financial implication are formidable in some areas.

An Educational Inspector in Maharashtra tried a very interesting experiment to meet this difficulty without involving additional expenditure. He grouped all schools within a radius of five or six miles into one unit, and placed them under the direct control of the Headmaster of a conveniently selected central school. Whenever the teacher in charge of a single-teacher school in the group desired to go on leave; he was required to get the permission of this Headmaster. He could easily do so because he lived within convenient distance of the controlling school. If the duration of the leave exceeded seven days, the Headmaster immediately sent one of his assistants to conduct the single-teacher school. The central school was short of one teacher no doubt; but as it was a multi-teacher school, the work could somehow be managed. As soon as a substitute was appointed by the head office and joined duties, the teacher of the central school

resumed his own post. In this way, all the extra financial burden involved in the former proposal is avoided and the work of the single-teacher school is kept going by shifting the inconvenience to a neighbouring multi-teacher school which can overcome it more easily. The plan also makes it possible to control the teachers of single-teacher schools when no efficient local school committee can be set up to supervise their work. In fact, the more one thinks of it, the more does one feel convinced that the experiment is full of potentialities and deserves wide recognition and publicity.

TRAINING OF TEACHERS

Coming to personnel problems, it is generally agreed in theory that the work in a single-teacher school is, in several ways, more difficult than that in a multi-teacher school. It is, therefore, essential to place the former under trained, capable and conscientious teachers. But in practice, this does not ordinarily happen. The single teacher schools are mostly situated in small scattered villages which are generally difficult of access and where amenities of life like a bazar, post office, good drinking water and medical aid are often not available. Teachers are, therefore, generally unwilling to serve in these schools. Moreover, the number of trained, capable and conscientious teachers is small and the bigger full-fledged primary schools have a prior claim on them. Consequently, it is usually the untrained and the junior teacher that happens to be posted to a single-teacher school; and very often, a recalcitrant teacher is transferred to it as a form of punishment! Under these conditions, it is hardly a matter for surprise if the quality of work turned out in single-teacher schools is generally poor.

The real solution of the problem is to increase the percentage of trained teachers to the maximum. State Governments should accept the principle that no primary teacher should be confirmed in service until he is trained; and they should take steps to so increase the number of training institutions that every new recruit to the cadre of primary teachers would either have been trained already or can be sent in for training within three to four years from the date of his appointment. If this reform is carried out, and if the recruitment to the cadre is carefully made—this may involve

a radical alteration in our present system of recruiting primary teachers and perhaps some reduction in the powers of local bodies in the matter—it will be possible to place single-teacher schools mostly under trained and capable teachers. In the meanwhile, the administering authorities should try to make the best of a bad situation and see to it that single-teacher schools are placed, as far as possible, in the charge of trained, or at least, conscientious teachers. Where it is not possible to do so for some reason or the other, the deficiency may be made up, to some extent at least, by arranging short refresher courses or by providing a closer supervision over the work of the teacher through a system of central school controls on the lines described earlier.

Whether the teachers of single-teacher schools need any special training for their job is another issue that arises in this context. Unfortunately, the problem has received but scant attention. Most of our training colleges for primary teachers are situated in urban areas and hence the trainees never get an opportunity to see a model single-teacher school in action or to practise in it. Moreover, the method of training usually adopted is to make the trainee give a number of isolated practice lessons. This is suitable for a multi-teacher school where a teacher is in charge of one class at a time or where the teaching is arranged subjectwise, but is hardly of any use in a single-teacher school. The special methods required to be adopted in a single-teacher school are not at all included in training institutions of several States, and the subject is totally neglected. In some States, the topic is included in the curriculum but its actual teaching becomes theoretical and unreal and is restricted to one or two lectures of a hackneyed type. It would, therefore, be no exaggeration to say that the average teacher who comes out of our training institutions is generally ignorant of the special methods to be adopted in single-teacher schools or is incapable of using them successfully. This is a matter which needs immediate attention. Since nearly 50 per cent of our primary schools are single-teacher institutions, it is almost a certainty that more than half of our teachers will have to serve in single-teacher schools for some part of their service. The special techniques to be adopted in single-teacher schools should, therefore, form an integral part of the curriculum of every training institution for primary teachers; every teacher under

training should be required to do continuous practice-teaching in a single-teacher school for a period of not less than a week; and most training colleges should either be shifted to rural areas or an experimental single-teacher school should necessarily be conducted in association with each of them. Another useful method would be to arrange special refresher courses, whose duration need not exceed about a week or two, and to make every teacher who has been placed in charge of a single teacher school to attend them.

EQUIPMENT

Equipment is an important aid to teaching and carefully planned equipment can often take the place of a teacher by setting the pupils to work on their own. A liberal provision of good equipment is, therefore, a great aid to a single-teacher school where the person in charge has to keep four different units of pupils simultaneously busy. Here too, the usual policy is to neglect the single-teacher schools and today they are the most poorly equipped of all. The earlier this unimaginative outlook is abandoned the better.

FRESH ADMISSIONS

Fresh admissions to the lowest primary class should be made in the first month or two months of the school year that the class becomes homogeneous and shows better progress. This rule is essential for all primary schools yet it is often not enforced in large areas. In single-teacher schools at any place, a scrupulous observance of this rule is very essential; otherwise, the local class gets subdivided into a number of further units depending upon the progress of children and the work of the teacher becomes all the more difficult.

SHIFT SYSTEM

A useful device to reduce the number of classes which the teacher of a single-teacher school has to handle at a time is to adopt the shift system—a scheme where the primary course consists of four classes, the adoption of a shift system would mean that the teacher has to handle only two classes at a time—a comparatively simple

affair. It would be very interesting to find out whether the children studying under such a plan learn less than those where the teacher teaches all the four classes at a time. The chances are that, in so far as the achievement of the pupils is concerned, the two systems would just be equal in result; and the shift system would have the additional advantage of making the task of the teacher lighter.

PRIVATE SINGLE-TEACHER SCHOOLS

So far, the problems of single-teacher schools under public management alone have been discussed. Some of the suggestions made above will also apply to single-teacher schools under private managements; but in certain respects, alternative measures will have to be adopted. The problem of the leave of teachers, for instance, is not acute in respect of private schools. It would be enough to insist that the management (who is very often the teacher himself) should make some acceptable arrangement for the work of the school to be carried on in the absence of the teacher on long leave and, as a safety measure, a panel cut in the grant-in-aid should be imposed if the school remains closed for a long time. Similarly, special facilities must be given to the teachers of private single-teacher schools to get themselves trained (i.e. by award of stipends, free-studentships in training institutions, etc.) and an inducement for the purpose may also be offered by giving a higher grant-in-aid to those schools which are in charge of trained teachers. Finally, liberal specific purpose grants should be given to these schools for the purchase of equipment and some of the equipment may also be supplied in kind.

RESEARCH AND PRODUCTION OF LITERATURE

Probably, the most important need of the hour is to carry out a good deal of research and experimentation on the problem. It would for instance, be interesting to compare the achievements of pupils in single and multi-teacher schools. The investigations carried out in Bombay by the Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics, Poona, showed that the single-teacher schools were not worse off than the multi-teacher schools in respect of stagnation, wastage and lapse into illiteracy. There is, therefore,

enough ground to feel that the evils of single-teacher schools have been unduly magnified and further investigations are urgently called for. Experiments to evolve better pedagogic techniques for use in single-teacher schools are of extreme importance and it is in this field that private enterprise can make a significant contribution. Further, it would be very useful to collate together the practical experience of good and successful teachers of single-teacher schools and make the useful devices discovered and used by them in actual practice known to the larger body of teachers through journals and suitably produced pamphlets. In USA a good deal of very useful literature is available to the workers in single-teacher schools. Kate V. Wofford's *Teaching in small schools or Modern Education in the Small Rural School* are good examples of such literature. In the various Indian languages such literature is conspicuous by its absence. The Government of India may do well to publish some literature on the subject in English and Hindi; the State Governments should then adapt it to their own local conditions and publish it in their regional languages as handbooks for teachers.

REFERENCES

1. Report, p. 525.
2. Report, pp. 60, 62 and 73.
3. Naik J.P., *Compulsory Primary Education in Baroda State* (Progress of Education, Poona, February, 1941).
4. Asiatic review, Jan. 1929, p. 89.
5. Report of The Hortog Committee, p. 73.
6. As Shri M.D. Jivanayakam writes: "Though a Chief Inspectress of Girls' schools has been retained and a few Assistant Inspectresses of schools for inspecting Girls' Middle and High Schools (English, Malayalam and Tamil), primary schools are now inspected by women or men Assistant Inspecting Officers whether they are boys' primary schools or girls' primary schools. Even in 1930, more girls studied in boys' schools than in girls' schools; but in 1930 the number of girls in co-educational schools was 1,38,350 out of a total 2,06,882; in 1939 it was 2,61,377 out of a total of 2,94,404. The staff has also become mixed. Therefore, there are now primary schools and not boys' primary schools and girls'

primary schools. This is very economic, as will be apparent in a place which has enough boys and girls to fill one school completely, but not enough boys for one school and enough girls for another. Under the old order where two schools with two *sets* of *staff* and equipment were necessary, now one school suffices."

(Primary Education in Travancore, *Teaching*, Vol., XIV, P. 125).

3

The Village Panchayats and Primary Education*

The modern trend of primary education all over the world is to make the primary school a centre for the local community. To do so, a close association between the primary school and the local community is necessary. Such association may come about through voluntary organisations such as Parent-Teacher Associations and/or through elected bodies in the local community such as Village Panchayats.

The Philippines and China have made great progress in such integration. In India, the principle is an essential aspect of basic education.

An association of the village school with the village community has several advantages. It becomes an important project in the social education of the adults; it is of great advantage to the school itself in improving its working; it secures additional financial resources to the support of the local school; and finally it provides several opportunities for training the students of the local school—who are the adult community members of tomorrow—in activities of social service.

Compulsory education can never become effective in rural areas until the local community is made to take interest in the local school and is made statutorily responsible for the enforcement of compulsory attendance.

In several parts of India, and particularly in Madras, attempts are being made to take the school closer to the people. The general experience is that, in all areas where such experiments are being tried, the local communities come forward to accommodate and equip the local schools and even to provide free mid-day meals to poor children.

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PROPOSED FUNCTIONS OF VILLAGE PANCHAYAT

Assuming that Village Panchayats are to be associated with the administration of local primary schools, the following is a tentative scheme:

With the trend unmistakably towards democratic decentralisation the Panchayats at long last are coming to their own in India. This welcome trend, however, has to prove its success: it can do so only if experience shows that the Panchayats can wield authority intelligently and exercise control with an awareness of the needs of the service it can provide to the people.

A great challenge and responsibility that rests on the Social Education worker is to create this awareness.

In the accompanying article, an eminent educationist indicates the role which the Panchayats can play in the field of primary education. He also indicates how the school, hitherto cut off from the community, can become a part of it.

The article has an obvious significance to the social education programme.

A list of the functions which may be assigned to the Village Panchayats in this behalf:

- a) to assist the Panchayat Samitis in the preparation and implementation of plans for the development of the primary education in their areas;
- b) to provide adequate accommodation and equipment for local primary schools;
- c) to carry out the current repairs of the school building and if directed by the Panchayat Samiti, to carry out special repairs and to construct new buildings;
- d) to provide for the welfare of the children attending local primary schools;
- e) to exercise such supervision over the local primary school as may be prescribed or may be directed by the Panchayat Samiti by a general or special order;
- f) to be responsible for the enforcement of compulsory attendance in the village in accordance with the Rules and Regulations prescribed for the purpose and general or special directives of the State Government and the Panchayat Samitis;

- g) subject to the funds at its disposal, to provide poor children with slates, books, clothes and other educational equipment;
- h) to be responsible for the proper management of the School Fund;
- i) to provide playgrounds and school gardens and to maintain them with the assistance of the pupils and the staff of the schools;
- j) to make provision for drinking water and other necessary amenities required by school children;
- k) to make provision, wherever possible, for midday meals to poor and undernourished children;
- l) to make provision for school uniforms;
- m) to celebrate school functions and to organise excursions or other social and cultural programmes in accordance with the instructions that may be issued by Government or the Panchayat Samiti from time to time; and
- n) generally to exercise such powers and perform such duties as the Panchayat Samiti may delegate from time to time.

Welfare of children is generally accepted as a responsibility of the Local Panchayat. This includes providing poor children with free supplies of books, slates and other educational equipment; and giving free mid-day meals if possible.

Cooperation of the Village Panchayat is necessary in locating and securing buildings for the local schools. Repairs can be carried out by Village Panchayats. Where the Village Panchayat is especially efficient the Panchayat Samiti might entrust them with special repairs or even the construction of new buildings.

Purchase of equipment by the Village Panchayat would encourage more careful handling than where such equipment is supplied from the outside, either by the Department or the Panchayat Samiti. It would encourage local initiative and competition in having better-equipped schools. Purchase at the local level would reduce the great delays in getting equipment inherent in central ordering. It would assure that the school received items of highest priority if the budget could not cover all times. Sometimes essential items are dropped in favour of less-needed items, when the decision must be made by the District Inspector.

Schools in poor or backward areas might suffer if supplying equipment is made the sole responsibility of the Village Panchayat. Also, bulk purchasing often results in considerable economy. Accordingly, some cooperative arrangement between the Village Panchayat and the Panchayat Samiti could be worked out, with the Village Panchayat arranging priorities and preparing the budget, and the Panchayat Samiti giving approval and indicating which items will be purchased in bulk.

Village Panchayats should assume almost exclusive responsibility for enforcing compulsory education. This includes preparing a census of school-age children; passing attendance orders; publishing lists of non-attending children and issuing notices to their parents; summoning defaulting parents before them; launching prosecution against defaulting parents where necessary; and granting exemptions in accordance with the Provisions of the Act and the regulations and general directives issued in this behalf.

VILLAGE SCHOOL COMMITTEE

In practice the Panchayats may set up a Village School Committee to handle functions related to the school. This Committee might best consist of four to eight village residents over 21 years of age, elected by the Village Panchayat, with at least half the members from itself. All members should be people interested in education, and there should be at least one woman and/or member from the backward classes. Committee members elected from outside the Panchayat should have passed primary standard V at least. The jurisdiction of the Committee should include all schools within the area of the Panchayat.

Under the Bombay Primary Education Rules, 1949, the powers of supervision to be given to the Village School Committee have been specifically enumerated. A Village committee is expected to:

- 1) visit all schools placed under its supervision at least once a month;
- 2) note whether the number of pupils in the school at the time of the visit corresponds with the number marked as present in the register and report any irregularity to the Administrative Officer;
- 3) report to the appropriate authorities any irregularity or unpunctuality in the matter of the opening and closing of the school and the teachers' attendance;

- 4) see that the school premises are in good repair and kept in a sanitary condition;
- 5) supervise the expenditure of grants placed at the disposal of the Head teacher;
- 6) permit the Head-teacher of the local school to leave his charge in case of emergency and to grant him casual leave of absence;
- 7) report the absence from school, without leave, of the Head - teacher and the assistant masters;
- 8) hold charge of the single-teacher schools in the event of the absence of the teacher on leave or in such other emergencies;
- 9) be present at the school at the time of the visit of any officer of the Education or other Departments;
- 10) be present at the time when the charge of the school is being handed over to another Head-teacher.

It would be wrong to draw up a standard list of powers of supervision to be delegated to all Village Panchayats. Conditions vary greatly from village to village. In some villages, there are even high schools at present and it is possible to have some trained graduates as members of Village Panchayats. It is suggested that two lists of powers of supervision be drawn up. Some of these powers, very simple in character, would be delegated necessarily to all Village Panchayats. Delegation of other powers would be left to the discretion of the Panchayat Samitis who by resolution would authorise individual Village Panchayats. Larger powers of supervision should be given to more efficient Village Panchayats and a power delegated should also be withdrawn in cases of misuse. This would create a healthy atmosphere of competition between the Village Panchayats. The aim would be to transfer powers to the local level as quickly as Village Panchayats could responsibly handle them.

SCHOOL FUND

In order to carry out its responsibilities, the Village School Committee should have a School Fund placed at its disposal. This fund can include a contribution from the Village Panchayat; voluntary contributions from the local community; all income from the school farm or crafts; fines realised in the locality under the Compulsory Education Act; such other miscellaneous items

as may be prescribed from time to time; and a grant-in-aid from the Panchayat Samiti. Ordinarily the Panchayat Samiti grant-in-aid would be proportional to local contributions, with higher percentages given to poor or backward villages.

CONTRIBUTION FROM THE VILLAGE PANCHAYAT

At present Village Panchayats are not required to make any contribution for the local schools. This is wrong in principle. Villages may need a higher proportion of grants-in-aid than municipalities, but both are local governments and both should be intimately associated with their local schools and made to pay for them. A minimum statutory contribution should be required. It could be smaller than for municipalities and could vary depending on the income of the Village Panchayat. It might be two per cent for Panchayats whose total annual income (exclusive of Government Grant) is less than Rs. 5,000 three per cent for those whose annual income is more than Rs. 5,000 but less than Rs. 10,000 and four percent in all other cases.

VOLUNTARY CONTRIBUTIONS

It is also suggested that every Village School Committee be authorised and encouraged to collect voluntary contributions and donations from the local public. A system of this type has existed in France since 1849 and it is now a national programme of great importance. Every school maintains a "School Chest" or Fund to which the local public makes voluntary contributions in cash or kind. In order to encourage such contributions, Government makes a definite grant-in-aid to every School Chest at a fixed proportion of the total amount collected locally. The whole amount, including the Government grant-in-aid, is placed at the disposal of the local School Committee for expenditure in connection with the school. It is usually utilised for such items as providing the school with equipment, managing the school gardens, taking the children out for excursion, providing extracurricular activities, providing free meals or clothes to poor children, etc. Such an institution deserves to be encouraged in our rural areas also.

It is felt that if the steps outlined above are taken, it would be possible to stimulate adequate local interest in the primary school as well as to evoke the largest possible local support for advancing primary education.

4

Objectives, Curricula and Methods of Teaching (1800-1937)*

EARLY VERNACULAR SCHOOLS

The word 'primary' or 'elementary' education came in use in modern Indian education rather late and, in the early days, there were only two types of schools which were mutually exclusive - English and Vernacular. The British officials who laid the foundations of the modern system of education in India were most concerned with one issue: how to impart a knowledge of western science and literature to the Indian people. This could obviously be done most easily through the medium of the English language and it was for this purpose that the scheme of English schools was devised - its object being to teach the English language in the first instance and then to introduce the student to the learning and culture of the West. Since English could be taught only to a small percentage of people, they also desired to impart Western culture and knowledge through the medium of the Indian languages and the system of 'vernacular' schools was first conceived for this purpose. The two systems were mutually exclusive and the 'vernacular' did not lead to the 'English'.

The system of vernacular schools grew up most conspicuously in the Province of Bombay between 1824 and 1854. The teachers of these schools, which usually had ten classes, were given a long course of pre-service training to enable them to teach their ambitious curriculum which included reading, writing, arithmetic, history of England and India, geography, astronomy, natural philosophy, algebra, Euclidean Geometry, and trigonometry. It would, therefore, be wrong to call them 'primary'

**NCERT, 1964